

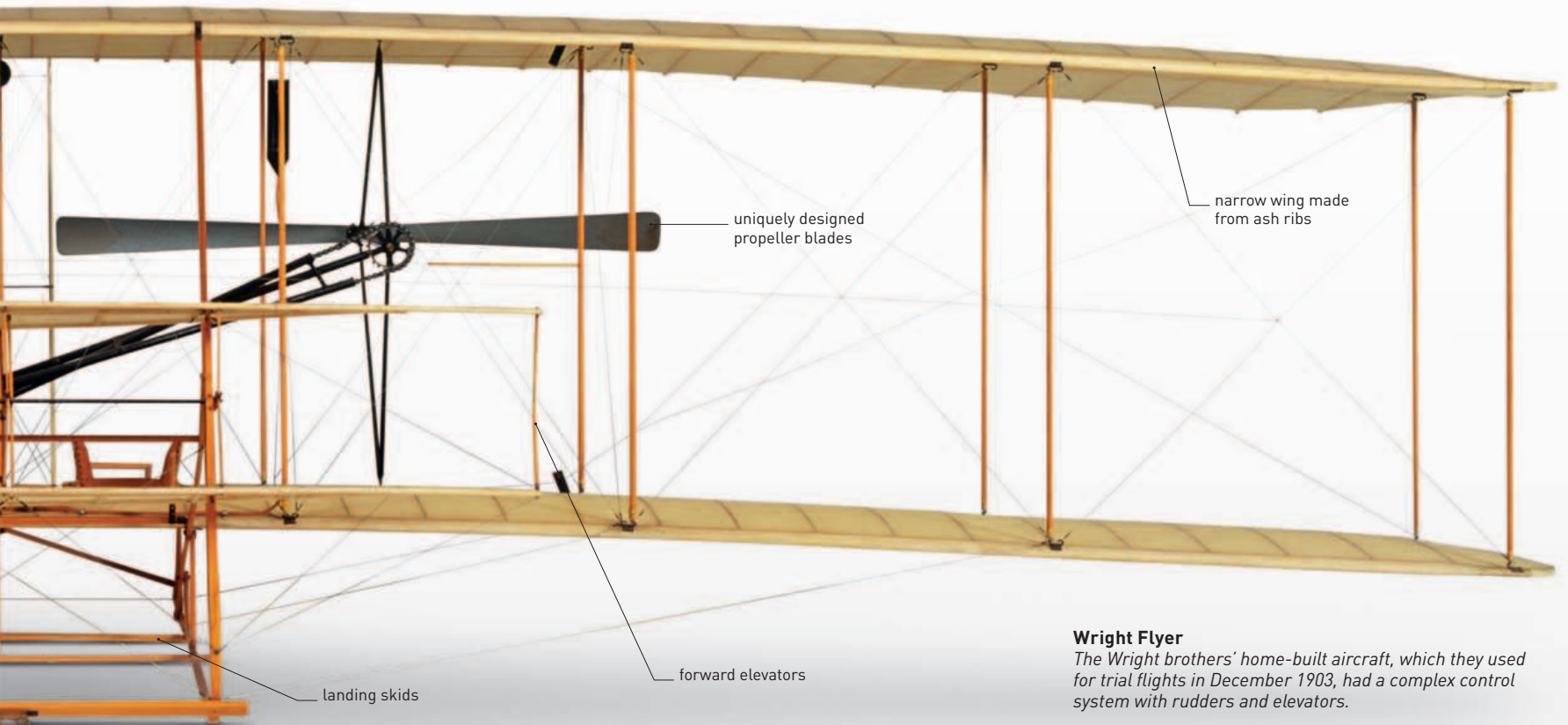
“ WE COULD NOT UNDERSTAND THAT THERE WAS ANYTHING ABOUT A **BIRD THAT COULD NOT BE BUILT** ON A LARGER SCALE. ”

Orville Wright (1873–1948), American aviation pioneer

American brothers Orville and Wilbur Wright made the first viable powered winged aircraft by attaching an engine to a glider in 1903. They solved the problem of controlling an aircraft in flight and by 1905 had a machine that would stay airborne until its fuel ran out. In the beginning, airships outperformed winged aircraft, but they were slow and fatally accident-prone. Successors to the

Wright brothers showed that winged aircraft had astounding potential for increase in size, range, and speed. By the 1930s, high-performance aircraft could exceed 400 mph (640 kph), while the development of flying instruments improved safety. Long-distance flying feats made pilots heroes in the 1920s and 1930s. But, by the 1940s, the same flights were available to paying

passengers in the comfort of pressurized cabins. Jet engines carried aircraft performance to supersonic speed and altitudes at the edge of space. Rocket technology then propelled humans into space itself. From the 1970s, falling prices turned flight into a worldwide mass transportation system and made it accessible to the majority. Air travel had bridged distances and shrunk the world.



Wright Flyer

The Wright brothers' home-built aircraft, which they used for trial flights in December 1903, had a complex control system with rudders and elevators.



Sikorsky VS-300

1930s

Helicopters evolve

The first helicopters are developed by Louis Breguet in France, the Focke-Wulf company in Germany, and Igor Sikorski in the US.



de Havilland Comet

1939

Jet aircraft

Englishman Frank Whittle invents the first jet engine. The first jet-propelled aircraft, the Heinkel He 178, makes successful test flight.



Concorde in flight

1952

First commercial jet

The prototype de Havilland Comet, the first commercial jet, takes off. Passenger air travel zooms into the jet age.

1976

Concorde enters service

Concorde, the world's first supersonic passenger aircraft, enters commercial service.

1927

First non-stop transatlantic flight

On May 20–21, American Charles Lindbergh flies solo, non-stop from New York to Paris in a single-engine monoplane.

1935

Air travel becomes cheaper

The Douglas DC-3 passenger aircraft makes flight cheaper and more viable.

1947

Supersonic flight

American aviator Chuck Yeager becomes the first to pilot the rocket-powered Bell X-1, the first aircraft to break the sound barrier.

1961

Manned spaceflight

Soviet cosmonaut Yuri Gagarin becomes the first man in space, orbiting the Earth in his Vostok spacecraft.



Space shuttle Columbia

1981

Reusable space craft

The space shuttle Columbia becomes the first shuttle to be launched into Earth's orbit, on April 12.



Spirit of St. Louis